

DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE: THE NOVELIZATION

CHAPTER ONE: The Anchor and the Earth

The wind in North Dakota doesn't just blow; it hunts.

It finds the gaps in your suit, the microscopic seams in your bespoke red spandex that you paid a cosplayer in Burbank way too much to double-stitch, and it works its way in like a lover with cold hands. It was the kind of cold that settled deep in the marrow, the kind that reminded you that the world was old, indifference, and entirely sick of your shit.

I stood there, boots crunching on the permafrost—a sound like stepping on a box of breakfast cereal wrapped in a wet towel—looking at the crude wooden cross. It was tilted, forty-five degrees. An X.

Cute. Branding is important, even in death. Especially in death.

Somewhere in the distance, The Platters were singing "Only You." It wasn't coming from anywhere specific. It was just *there*, vibrating in the air molecules, an earworm manifested by the sheer narrative weight of the moment. Or maybe I'd left a Bluetooth speaker on a rock somewhere. It's hard to keep track of inventory when you're having a mental breakdown.

You know, I thought, the internal monologue running on the dual-tracks of a manic narrator and a cynical game dev crunching for a patch release, *for a long time I wasn't sure I'd ever be back. The Corporate Overlords—praise be to the Mouse, hallowed be His ears—bought the Fox house. It was a hostile takeover of the server. There was a whole boring rights issue, a bureaucratic dungeon crawl of IP lawyers and non-compete clauses that would make a Kafka protagonist drink bleach.*

We were in Purgatory. Not the biblical one, which probably has better catering, but the Hollywood one. The Grey Zone. The Void where franchises go to wait for a reboot or a streaming series that nobody asked for.

But then it turned out they wanted me.

Me. The Merc with the Mouth. The Regenerating Degenerate. The one guy who shouldn't even have his own movie, much less a franchise. It's like inviting the hobo who screams at pigeons to the Royal Wedding because he once correctly guessed the Queen's weight to the decimal point.

Marvel's so stupid.

I looked at the grave. A coffee mug sat perched on a rock nearby, frost forming on its ceramic lip. "I LIKE ME." It was an affirmation. It was a lie. It was merchandise.

Look, Constant Nerd, I told the air, addressing the fourth wall that was currently thinner than the ozone layer, *we all saw the trailer. We know the title of this thing. I see you typing on your forums. I see your Reddit threads. I know what you're wondering. How are we going to do this without dishonoring Logan's memory? How do we navigate the Sacred Timeline without taking a steaming dump on the grave of the only serious, Oscar-nominated movie this franchise ever made?*

I grabbed the shovel. The handle was cold enough to burn skin, but my skin was a topography of scar tissue and cancer, so I didn't feel much. Just the pressure. The weight of the tool.

And I'll tell you how...

I drove the spade into the frozen earth. It resisted. The ground was hard as iron, frozen since the Cretaceous period.

...We're not.

Digging a grave is hard work.

In the movies, it's a montage. A few rhythmic scoops, some dramatic lighting, maybe a slow-motion shot of sweat flying off a bicep. In reality, it's a grind. It's manual labor in a server that has turned the physics engine up to 'Punishing.'

I dug.

The shovel hit dirt. *Thunk.*

It hit a root. *Crack.*

It hit a rock. *Clang.*

My shoulders burned. My healing factor was working overtime, knitting torn muscle fibers back together as fast as I could tear them. It was a cycle of destruction and rebirth, played out in the microcosm of my deltoids.

You think I want to be out here in Butt-Fuck North Dakota digging up the one and only Wolverine? No thank you. I'd rather be at home, watching the Great British Bake Off and seeing if Paul Hollywood's eyes can actually impregnate a contestant through the screen. I'd rather be playing Hello Kitty Island Adventure. I'd rather be doing literally anything else.

But the fate of my entire world was at stake. My timeline was dying. My friends were dying. My server was shutting down.

He may not be living his best life, but he sure as hell ain't dead.

Regenerative healing factors don't just stop. They are the glitch in the system. The cheat code that keeps the game running when it should have crashed to desktop. Logan wasn't dead. He was just buffering. He was stuck in a respawn loop.

SHUNK.

The sound was different.

It wasn't dirt. It wasn't rock. It was metal on something... else. Something hollow. Something wooden.

"Well, there you are," I said, my breath pluming like dragon smoke in the frigid air. "Yes, yes, yes, yes."

I scrambled down into the hole, a red-suited mole rat in a fever dream. I cleared the dirt with my hands. My gloves were torn, my fingernails packed with frozen mud. I clawed at the earth like a man possessed. Like a fanboy trying to open a mint-condition action figure without damaging the box.

I cleared the last layer. I found the lid of the makeshift coffin. I pried it open.

And I stopped.

The air in the grave was still. It smelled of decay, yes, but dry decay. Old dust.

It was... disappointing.

It was bone.

Just bone. Adamantium-laced, sure, shiny and chrome like a car bumper in a showroom, but bone nonetheless. The metal had fused with the calcium, creating a lattice of indestructible failure.

There was no flesh. No muscle. No growl. No scowling Australian refusing to help me. Just a skeleton wearing the tattered remains of a tank top.

"Come on," I whispered. My voice cracked. "Son of a bitch."

I stood up in the grave. The frustration boiled over, hot and acidic.

"AGHH MOTHER-FUCKER-- MY WORLD IS FUCKED!"

I swung the shovel.

It connected with the cross—*CRACK*—sending wood spinning into the grey sky. I smashed it again. The vibration traveled up my arms, rattling my teeth in their sockets. I smashed it until the handle splintered. I broke the shovel across my thigh, the sound of the wood snapping echoing like a gunshot in the silence.

I tossed the pieces into the hole.

The metal tip of the shovel bounced off the adamantium ribcage—*CLANG*—and flew back out, a final middle finger from the universe. A physics glitch.

I spun around, dizzy, the world tilting on its axis, and fell backward into the hole.

Just me and the skeleton. The Odd Couple. One rotting, one unable to rot. Lying in the dirt, waiting for the credits to roll.

"That was weird," I said to the corpse, staring up at the rectangle of grey sky. "I'm much calmer now. Look, I'm not a man of science, but you seem incredibly passed away."

I sighed. The wind howled above us, a lonely, mournful sound.

"But it's good to see ya."

I climbed out. I sat on the edge of the grave, legs dangling. I pulled the skeleton up next to me. We leaned against the tree. The same tree where he died in *Logan*. The tree that made grown men cry in theaters across the world.

He was sitting there, or what was left of him. The adamantium skeleton was posed casually, legs folded. If he hadn't been a grim collection of metal and rot, it would have looked like two dudes hanging out in the woods, maybe sharing a beer, maybe talking about how the fishing was.

"I've gotta be honest," I said, leaning in. "I've always wanted to ride with you, Log'. You and me, getting into it. Deadpool and Wolverine just fucking shit up. Can you imagine the fun? The chaos? The residuals?"

I switched to the accent. I couldn't help it. It was a defense mechanism. A mask over the mask.

"G'day mate. There's nothing that'll bring me back to life faster than a big bag of Marvel cash."

I dropped the accent. It tasted bitter.

"Me too, Hugh. But no. No, no, no. You had to get all noble and die for real. Goddamnit, I could really use your help right now—"

The air shimmered.

It wasn't the heat. It was a tear in the fabric of reality. A digital glitch in the high-res texture of the woods.

A glowing orange rectangle appeared. The kind that screamed *Load Zone*.

A Time Door.

They spilled out like ants from a kicked hill. The Minutemen. The TVA. The fun police of the multiverse. The moderators of the server.

They looked upgraded since their last patch notes. Better armor—matte black, tactical, useless against main characters. Bigger sticks—glowing with the prune energy that erased you from existence.

I popped my head out of the grave like a gopher in a red condom.

"WAIT! I'm warning you! I'm not alone."

"Wade Winston Wilson!" one of them shouted. His voice was amplified, distorted. "You are under arrest by the Time Variance Authority for too many crimes to list. Come out and we'll give you the courtesy of taking you in one piece."

"Ughhhh," I groaned, sliding back down into the dirt. "Death by day-player."

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CHAPTER TWO: Maximum Effort

"Last chance: Throw out your weapons and come out peacefully."

The voice came from everywhere and nowhere, amplified by the kind of high-end PA system that tax dollars shouldn't be buying for time cops.

I looked at the skeleton. I looked at the adamantium ribs, shining like silverware in a drawer that hadn't been opened since the 1990s. The strongest metal in the universe, woven into the calcium of a man who spent his life hurting.

"I'm not gonna give you my weapons," I called out, my voice bouncing off the frozen hills.

I grabbed Logan's hand. It was cold. Not just winter cold. Dead cold. The kind of cold that absorbs heat from everything it touches.

"But I promise not to use *them*."

I turned to the camera—the invisible lens that I knew was there, the eye of the Constant Nerd, the voyeur in the darkened theater of my mind.

"There are 206 bones in the human body," I whispered, feeling the geometry of the skeleton. "207 if I'm watching Gossip Girl."

I high-fived the skeletal hand. The sound was a dry *clack*, like billiard balls colliding.

"Here we go. **Maximum Effort**."

The music started. Not in the world, but in the soundtrack of the universe. *NSync.* "Bye, Bye, Bye." A song so catchy it was classified as a biological weapon by the Geneva Convention.

I moved.

It wasn't a jump; it was an eruption. I flew out from behind the dirt pile, holding Logan's skeleton by the neck like a macabre dance partner. The vertebrae rattled.

"Okay, Peanut. Guess we're getting that team up after all."

I landed in the snow. The Minutemen hesitated. Just for a frame. It was the hesitation of men who were expecting a surrender and got a corpse-wielding maniac instead.

That hesitation was all I needed.

I grabbed an adamantium rib. I pulled.

Snap.

The sound was wet and sharp, like stepping on a dry branch wrapped in wet leather. The connective tissue—rotted, frozen, but still there—gave way. I held the curved bone in my hand. It was perfectly balanced. A scimitar made of a superhero.

I threw it.

The bone didn't fly; it deleted space. It spun through the air, catching the pale winter light. As it flew, I saw the text. Giant, floating, 3D letters manifesting in the air like a localized hallucination. **THE MARVEL CINEMATIC UNIVERSE PRESENTS.**

The rib hit the lead Minuteman in the chest.

THWACK-CRUNCH.

The sound of metal punching through futuristic polymer armor and the sternum beneath was sickeningly distinct. It was the sound of a heavy book being slammed onto a counter of raw meat. The Minuteman went down, gasping, pink froth bubbling at the intake of his helmet.

I moved into the dance. I wasn't fighting; I was editing.

I snapped off the clavicles. Dual-wielding collarbones.

A Minuteman lunged with a Time Stick. The orange energy crackled, promising erasure. I parried with a thigh bone—still attached to the shin by rotting tendons, a flail of indestructible death.

I swung it like Bruce Lee on bath salts.

WHACK.

The heavy end of the femur connected with a helmet. The faceplate shattered. The head inside did something worse. It didn't just break; it caved. It was a soft melon meeting a sledgehammer. The Minuteman dropped without a sound, just a sack of meat suddenly devoid of the electrical impulse to stand.

A FILM BY SHAWN LEVY. The letters appeared in the spray of blood.

"Mullin! I'm outside the box!" I screamed, ripping another rib loose.

I stabbed. The jagged end of the rib slid into a throat. There was resistance—skin, cartilage, muscle—and then a hot spray of arterial red that painted the snow in an abstract expressionist nightmare. It was warm. Sticky. Real.

This wasn't CGI. This was wet work. This was the Blackmore texture pack.

I grabbed the pelvis. A shield. A weapon. I slammed it into a Minuteman, driving him back. He stumbled, his own Time Stick brushing his leg.

ZZRRRPT.

He pruned himself. Gone. Erased from the server. A cloud of purple smoke where a man used to be.

"Come on, big fella."

I grabbed the forearms.

I widened the radius and ulna, sliding my own gloved arms inside the thoracic cage of the forearm bones. They fit. Like they were made for me. Like a hug from a ghost.

I stood there, breathing heavy, the cold air burning my lungs. The Minutemen regrouped, uncertain. They were looking at a madman wearing a dead superhero like a suit of armor.

I flexed my wrists.

****SHNIKT.****

The claws popped.

The sound was pure. It was the sound of consequences. It was the sound of a promise kept.

I stood hunched, backlit by the winter sun, the adamantium blades extending from my fists, dripping with snow and potential violence.

"I am soaking wet right now," I growled.

And then I roared. A primal sound, half-animal, half-glitch, echoing across the frozen wastes of North Dakota, promising pain, promising chaos, promising a sequel.

Freeze Frame.

Record Scratch.

Voiceover Mode: Engaged.

To be clear, I'm not proud of any of this. The wanton violence. The whiff of necrophilia. It isn't who I am. It isn't who I want to be.

Who I want to be... well, that's a different story. A simpler story. A story before the rot set in. To help you understand that, I've gotta take you back. Back before the timeline turned into a dumpster fire.

Flashback noise. *Wavy lines.* *Harp music.*

****March, 2018. Earth-616.****

The office smelled of money. Not the dirty, crumpled singles of a mercenary's duffel bag, but the clean, digital scent of assets that appreciate while you sleep. The kind of money that builds towers with names on them.

I sat in the chair, vibrating. My leg was doing a drum solo on the carpet. *Tap-tap-tap.*

I was wearing a hoodie. I probably shouldn't have worn a hoodie. But it was my nice hoodie. The one without the bloodstains.

Across the desk sat a man who looked like he'd been manufactured in a factory that specialized in "Middle Management: Friendly Edition." Harold Lloyd. Or at least, that's what the nameplate said. To me, he looked like Happy Hogan, the guy who carried Tony Stark's bags.

"Thank you, sir," I said, my voice tight. "For seeing me. I firmly believe that my services could be of great use to your organization."

I tried to look professional. I tried to look like a man who didn't solve problems with katanas and high explosives. I looked around the room. It was a shrine to Tony Stark. Iron Man masks, awards, tech that probably cost more than the GDP of a small country.

"Now, I know I was caught 'Smashturbating' in the lobby of Stark Towers," I continued, rushing the words, tripping over my own desperation. "But I can assure you--"

Harold blinked. "Smashturb-- I'm sorry. What was that?"

"Oh. No, I'm sorry." I waved a hand. "That's when you get those toy Hulk Hands, right, and then you just look down, and you just-- you brace yourself, and you ravage the midsection--"

"I get it, okay," Harold interrupted, his face tightening. "Thank you. The picture's painted."

"You get the gist."

I shifted in the chair. The leather squeaked. It was the sound of a balloon animal being strangled.

This is going poorly, the cynical voice in my head—the Jun Prince filter—observed. *You are an NPC trying to glitch your way into the Main Quest. You are a Level 1 Crook trying to talk to the Guild Master.*

"What exactly brings you here today?" Harold asked.

I took a breath. This was it. The moment. The pitch.

"Why am I--? Wow... Okay." I leaned forward. "I care... I know I turn everything into a joke, but I care, and I want to use that feeling for something important. I want to matter. And to show my girl that I matter."

I looked over my shoulder. The door was closed.

"I feel like I'm wasting the good stuff here... is the Man not gonna be joining us?"

Harold frowned. "The Man?"

"Yeah. I should save this if he's gonna--"

"As far as you're concerned right now, I'm the Man..."

"No."

"The Man is me. I am the Man in this circumstance. He doesn't do this kind of thing anymore."

"Cameos?"

"Meetings. Entry level meetings."

The words hung in the air like a fart in an elevator. *Entry level.*

"Entry level?" I squinted at him. "Aren't you the Chauffeur, maybe...?"

"A common misconception. I did begin my career as Mr. Keaton's driver."

"Chauffeur."

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CHAPTER THREE: Aim for the Middle

"You seem to have left out whether or not you had any experience as a member of a team," Harold said, his pen hovering over my resume like a drone waiting to strike. "Could you maybe add a little bit of perspective there?"

"Oh no, yes. Of course." I nodded enthusiastically, a bobblehead of desperation. "I was Special Forces, but mainly I was team leader -- founder, really -- of X-Force. Sadly, they all perished in action."

Harold wrote something down. *Scratch. Scratch.*

"How exactly did that happen?"

"Well, the police say 'gravity'," I said, leaning in as if sharing a trade secret. "But just between us, they didn't test well in the focus group, mainly because of Cable. The demographic skew was all wrong. Too much pouch, not enough synergy."

Harold made another note. A bad note. The kind of note that gets your resume put in the "Do Not Call" pile, right next to the guys who write their cover letters in crayon or attach a headshot where they're holding a katana.

"Whoa, oh oh!" I held up a hand. "I can see this isn't going well. Please stop writing. I just... Look..."

My eyes felt hot. Desperation. It's a bitter taste, like licking a 9-volt battery that's been marinated in disappointment.

"I wanna be an Avenger."

Harold stopped writing. He looked at me. Really looked at me. He saw the scars under the hoodie. He saw the frantic energy of a man who knows his franchise is on the bubble.

"I want to be an Avenger."

"Why do you want to be an Avenger?"

"Because look around you," I said, gesturing to the room, to the legacy on the walls. The Iron Man helmets staring back with hollow, judgmental eyes. "They're the best of the best. And what they do matters. I need to be an Avenger. Sir, my girl has kind of had it with my shtick. And if I don't turn things around and do something with my gifts, I don't think it's really going to work out for me, and I wouldn't blame her."

It was the truth. The raw, bleeding truth. And in a room full of corporate superhero branding, truth felt like a foreign contaminant.

Harold leaned back. The leather chair groaned under the weight of his authority.

"Avengers are a very unique group of superheroes that stand for something more than just fighting and wearing costumes," he said, reciting the company mission statement. "I mean, people look up to us. Kids look up to us."

"I'm sorry, *us*?" I blinked. The filter slipped. "I wasn't aware that you were an Avenger..."

"Avengers-adjacent, technically--"

"Oh wow, what's your superpower? Is it parallel parking?" The words were out before I could stop them. My mouth, the traitor. The defense mechanism that fires shrapnel when I'm scared. "I'm so sorry. That was cruel. I lash out when I'm nervous. It won't happen again."

Harold stood up.

"Let's cut to the chase."

"Please."

"You just said, moments ago, that you wanted to be an Avenger because you need it."

"Yessir, I do."

"But the Avengers don't do the job because they need it. They do the job because people need *them*. Do you see the distinction?"

I felt small. Smaller than an atom. Smaller than the chances of this working out. It was the crushing weight of realization: I was playing a different game. I was playing *Grand Theft Auto*; he was playing *SimCity*.

"Yessir. Please, Mr. Lloyd. I don't want to spend the rest of my life like an annoying one trick pony."

"Alright."

He walked me to the door. He put a hand on my shoulder. It was meant to be comforting. It felt like a dismissal. It felt like being escorted out of a mall by security.

"The problem might be that you're reaching a little too high," he said. "Aim for the middle and you'll never miss, right? I think you've got a good heart. I believe what you're saying. But not everybody's the world-saving type. I'm not. But I'm happy, right? I found my place. Find your place."

I stood in the doorway. The hallway stretched out behind me, long and empty.

"Alright, get back out there. We'll keep an eye on you. Good luck."

I hugged him. I hugged him hard. It was awkward. It lingered. It was a hug that said, *Please validate my existence.*

"Alright, fetch the car. I want to hit Shake Shack on the way home."

"Really? Really? -- No, no, please."

I pulled away.

"Okay, thank you."

I walked away. The door closed.

SHUNK. SHUNK. SHUNK.

The sound echoed in the darkness.

You know what they say, the narrator whispered, the voice tired and old. *When one door closes, your locker at work opens.*

Earth-10005. Now.

The locker room smelled of Old Spice, damp towels, and the specific, metallic scent of resignation. It was the smell of men who had given up on their dreams and settled for a dental plan.

SHUNK.

I pressed the staple gun against my scalp.

The pain was sharp, immediate, and grounding. It was a reminder that I was still here, still flesh and blood, even if the spirit had left the building years ago. The staple pierced the scar tissue, biting into the periosteum of the skull.

SHUNK.

I was attaching a hair system. A toupee. A chestnut-colored lie that sat on my scarred head like a dead squirrel.

This is the build now, I told myself, looking into the mirror. The face staring back wasn't Deadpool. It was Wade. Just Wade. *We re-specced. We dropped the 'Regenerating Degenerate' class and picked up 'Used Car Salesman.' The stats are terrible—Charisma is a dump stat, Stamina is average—but the stealth rating is off the charts. Nobody looks at a used car salesman. They look through him.*

I straightened my nametag. 'WADE.'

I buttoned my cuffs. I tied my Skechers Shape-Ups.

"Now let's go sell some certified pre-owned vehicles, motherfuck--"

The Kia Carnival is not a minivan. It is an MPV. That's what the brochure says. That's what I tell the customers. That's what I tell myself when I wake up screaming.

It's a Multi-Purpose Vehicle. It implies adventure. It implies choice. It implies that you haven't completely given up on the concept of joy.

I was sitting in the back, 'riding bitch,' squeezed between two kids who smelled like fruit snacks and sticky fingers. The parents, the Chipmans, were in the front. Mr. Chipman was driving like he was afraid the car might actually do something interesting.

"Technically, the Carnival is not a... minivan," I said, my voice dropping out on the forbidden M-word. It was a taboo. A curse word in the religion of suburban denial. "It's an 'MPV.' So everybody gets to keep their testicles."

Mrs. Chipman turned around. Her face was a mask of suburban disapproval. "So how does the Kia compare to the Honda Odyssey?"

"That's a great question. Um, it doesn't fucking suck."

"You know, you can answer the question without swearing."

"I'm sorry, Tammy! I don't have kids. Not that I haven't dreamt of that, but I don't have a lot of vaginal sex."

Silence. The kind of silence that makes you wish for a sudden, violent car crash. The kind of silence that fills the space where a soul used to be.

"Right here at the light," I said, pointing with a hand that used to hold a Desert Eagle. "And then back onto the lot."

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CHAPTER FOUR: The Support Class

"You'll get 'em next time."

The voice was warm, soft, and completely out of place in a room that smelled of foot fungus and shattered dreams.

I turned around.

Peter.

Peter was back. In all his mustachioed glory. He was wearing a polo shirt and khakis that defied the laws of thermodynamics—wrinkle-free, stain-free, and radiating an aura of aggressive normalcy.

Peter was an anomaly. In a universe of mutants, cyborgs, and gods, Peter was a guy named Peter who just wanted to help. He was the ultimate NPC who had somehow glitch-walked into the main party and refused to leave.

"And look," he said, opening his locker with the reverence of a priest opening a tabernacle. "You can always go back to superheroing. I mean, I know I'd like to see you back in the suit. I don't keep it in my locker so that *I* can wear it."

He laughed. It was a longing sound, a laugh that hid a thousand unwritten fanfics.

"I keep it in my locker in case we need to saddle up again."

I looked inside.

There it was. The Suit.

It hung on a shitty wire hanger, limp and lifeless. Without me inside it, it looked like a flayed skin. The red was dull in the fluorescent light. The black patches looked like bruises. It was a relic. An artifact from a previous patch version of reality where I was the main character.

"Hey, hey hey," I said, my voice dropping to a whisper. "What is it doing in there? I'm done. I'm done, and I'm fine with being done."

I wasn't fine. I was lying. I was lying to Peter, and worst of all, I was lying to the narrator.

"Look, is sales the best match? Probably not. Is this the life that I always imagined for myself? Fuck no. But this is the right fit for me, Sugar Bear. It is."

"Okay, Mr. Wilson."

"Aim for the middle and you'll never miss."

The words tasted like ash. They tasted like Harold Lloyd's breath mints and condescension.

We biked home. Just two grown men riding bicycles through the city, one of them wearing a toupee stapled to his head, the other radiating pure, unadulterated Peter-energy.

The city was grey. It was the kind of evening where the streetlights hummed with a low-frequency anxiety.

"I'm just saying... once a month, we could go on uhhhh little mission," Peter panted, pedaling hard to keep up with my genetically enhanced thighs. "We're human beings. We crave purpose. After all, we're Deadpool."

"Please, stop saying that. We're not Deadpool. I'm not even Deadpool anymore."

"Well, if you're gonna have a midlife crisis... go BIG. A few years ago, a friend of mine got his nipples pierced with a titanium chain that goes down and attaches to his Van-Johnson."

I hit the brakes. We stopped outside my building. Peter locked the bikes up with a chain that looked sturdy enough to hold a velociraptor.

I looked across the street.

There was a feeling. A prickle on the back of my neck. Not the Spidey-Sense—don't sue me, Sony—but something similar. The feeling of being watched. The feeling of the crosshairs.

Construction workers. They were digging near the subway entrance. But they weren't digging. They were standing. Watching. Their hard hats were too clean. Their vests were too orange.

NPC behavior, the Prince filter analyzed. *Idle animations. They're waiting for a trigger event.*

"Are you feeling grumplestilskin 'cause it's your birthday?" Peter asked, oblivious to the potential ambush.

"What?... No..."

I shook it off. Just paranoia. Just the PTSD of a man who spent years expecting ninjas to drop from the ceiling.

I headed inside.

"Surprise!"

The lights flickered on. My apartment—usually a sanctuary of depression and dirty laundry—was transformed. Balloons. Streamers. Crepe paper. It looked like a Party City had exploded.

And the people. My people.

Dopinder. Blind Al. Colossus. Negasonic Teenage Warhead. Yukio. Shatterstar. Buck.

And Vanessa.

"Hey! You guys are lucky I'm not armed," I said, forcing a smile. It was a good smile. I'd practiced it in the mirror between sales pitches.

"Get in here. If this were five years ago, you'd all be dead."

I worked the room. I played the part. *Wade Wilson, Used Car Salesman, Normal Guy, Birthday Boy.*

I hugged Dopinder. I hugged Colossus (it was like hugging a refrigerator). I hugged Shatterstar (who smelled of hair gel and alien musk).

Then, the small talk. The social combat.

"Make any sales today?" Blind Al asked. She was sitting on the couch, wearing sunglasses indoors, looking like the matriarch of a very aggressive crime family.

"You know, I didn't. Did you sell any dreamcatchers on ETSY? Or whatever it is that you do?"

"Our rent is due in three days, Wade. I can't keep carrying you."

"Relax. I have the money. I sold some old blood pressure medication I found lying around."

"Are you trying to kill me, motherfucker?"

"I'm not the one dousing everything in salt, motherfucker."

"I pray everyday that fire finds your body and finishes the job God didn't have the nuts to do."

"That's hurtful. If you could hear the look on my face, you'd smell how sad I am."

"Whatever."

I moved on. The conversation was a minefield of feigned interest.

Colossus was standing by the dip, looking massive and metallic.

"You watching anything good?" I asked.

"Great British Bake Off."

"Oh goddamn. That show stood between me and suicide for ten years. Paul Hollywood is a national treasure."

I turned to the girls. Negasonic Teenage Warhead looked as surly as ever. Yukio looked like a rainbow made of kindness.

"Hi Yukio!"

"Hi Wade!"

"Nice fake-o'clock shadow," Negasonic muttered.

"It's a summer balayage. From the french. It's meant to mimic the natural highlights of the sun."

"It's a toupée."

"It's a hair system."

"I love your hair system, Wade!" Yukio chirped.

I drifted back to Blind Al. She was leaning in, conspiring.

"Wanna do some cocaine?" she whispered.

"Hey! Cocaine is the one thing that Feige said is off limits!" I hissed, looking at the ceiling as if the Marvel sniper was already aiming. "We are in the House of Mouse now, Al! Do you want to get us cancelled? Do you want to be pruned?"

"What about Bolivian marching powder?"

"They know all the slang terms. They have a list. A list curated by executives who think 'darn' is strong language."

"Even snowballing?"

"Even disco dust."

"White girl interrupted?"

"Even Forest bump."

"Booger sugar?"

"You can't even say Diego Maradona, and he's a legend."

"Do you want to build a snowman?" she asked, quoting the sacred text.

"Yes. But I can't."

I walked away. The room felt small. The air felt thin. I was surrounded by love, and I felt like I was drowning in it.

DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE: THE NOVELIZATION

CHAPTER FIVE: The Sacred Timeline

"How's work?" I asked, my voice cracking slightly on the syllable, a teenager hitting puberty in the middle of a sentence.

"Oh, I got a promotion," Vanessa said. She was glowing. Not literally—though in this universe, you never know—but she had that aura of someone who has their shit together. "It's mind numbing middle management, but I'm happy."

"That's great. You seeing anyone?"

I braced myself. I tightened my abdominal muscles, as if expecting a gut punch from Colossus.

"Um, yeah. A guy from work. Dermot."

Dermot.

The name landed like a wet sock. *Dermot.* It sounded like a skin condition. It sounded like the kind of guy who wears sandals with socks and has strong opinions about craft beer.

"Dermot?" I repeated, tasting the bile.

"He's kind. Likes to go hiking. Hasn't gotten me shot yet."

Ouch. Critical hit. That one bypassed my armor class entirely.

"Well it's early days," I managed to say, my smile feeling like it was held in place by duct tape.

"What about you? You seeing anyone?"

"No, no. I live in a one bedroom apartment. I share a bed with Blind AI."

We smiled. It was polite. It was the kind of smile you give someone at a funeral when you don't know what to say. It was excruciating.

We gathered around the table. The cake was there, flickering with candles that smelled of cheap wax and impending mortality.

"Speech! Speech! Speech!"

I raised my hands. The room went quiet. I looked at them. My family. My weird, broken, beautiful family.

"Okay, okay, okay. Birthdays. Boy, every spin around the moon is a new adventure indeed--"

"Sun, dumbass," Blind AI grunted.

"OK, round-earthier. Where was I?"

"The adventure of life," Colossus supplied helpfully.

"Right. It's been a challenging few years, for sure. I've been through a lot. A change of life."

"Andropause?" Buck asked.

"Bitch, are you improv'ing?!" I snapped. "(then, to Yukio) I'm sorry that you had to see that, Yukio."

"It's okay."

I looked at Vanessa. She was smiling. Not at me, really. Just smiling.

"But I'm happy. And that's because of each and every one of you... And this is about how proud I am. How grateful I am to be standing in a room with every single person I love."

I paused. I let the silence hang there.

"I'm the luckiest man alive."

"Make a wish, buddy," Vanessa said softly.

"Ten-four good buddy. Going down."

I leaned in. The candles flickered in my eyes. The heat was close.

I wish I mattered.

I blew them out.

KNOCK. KNOCK. KNOCK.

The sound didn't belong in a sitcom. It was heavy. Authoritative. It was the sound of the Genre Police coming to shut down the production.

I sighed. "I'll get it."

I walked to the door. The hallway was dark.

I opened it.

Three men stood there. They were wearing armor that looked like it cost more than the building. Black, tactical, with glowing orange accents. They held batons that hummed with a low, menacing frequency.

"Wade Wilson?" the lead Minuteman asked.

"Oh, yeah. The answer's Dopinder must have ordered you."

I looked at their outfits. "Are those supposed to be cop costumes? Never mind. Take your clothes off, but leave the helmets, and this isn't *Pretty Woman*."

I popped a mint into my mouth.

"We're kissing, alright. Which song do you guys normally dance to?"

I looked back into the room. Nobody had noticed. The party was still going. The laugh track was still playing.

The Minuteman raised his Time Stick.

"Whoa, whoa. Is that supposed to be scary? Pegging isn't new for me, friendo." I winked. "But it is for Disney."

They stepped forward. The air pressure in the hallway dropped.

"Ah-ta-ta... look, I've never been a natural bottom so we're going to take things real slow and I want some crazy eye contact. Not you. *You*." I pointed to the one in the back. "I can't see your eyes through the mask, but I can feel them."

"I don't like you," the leader said.

"Yes. Let's hold onto that attitude and we're going to do it angry."

I squared up. I was ready to fight. I was ready to defend my party, my friends, my sad little life.

But you don't fight the System. The System just edits you.

A door opened behind me. Not a wooden door. A door of light. A rectangular hole in reality.

An arm reached out—armored, strong—and grabbed me by the back of the neck.

I was yanked backward.

The hallway vanished. The party vanished.

My toupee—my beautiful, stapled-on hair system—fell off, landing on the floor where I had just stood. A chestnut-colored tombstone for Wade Wilson.

The Time Variance Authority.

I woke up sitting in a chair. My head was on a table.

I gasped, sitting up.

"Mr. Wilson. You appear to have soiled yourself while unconscious."

I looked across the table. A man was sitting there. He was wearing a suit that was tailored to within an inch of its life. He looked like a British banker who had just foreclosed on an orphanage and felt good about it.

"I wasn't unconscious. Who are you?"

"I go by the name of Paradox. Mr. Paradox. And you're sitting here at the TVA. The Time Variance Authority."

"We're really a watchdog organization," he continued, his voice smooth as expensive scotch. "Except we're more lighthearted than that sounds. With a sort of throwback ironic twist. And we're in charge of

defending what's known as the 'Sacred Timeline.'"

"That is a shit-ton of exposition for a threequel," I muttered. "Is this because I used Cable's time machine? I brought a couple of people back to life. Then I destroyed it. That was a long time ago..."

"Yes, we're aware of your abuse of your timeline. And you were so abusive of it. And no, it has nothing to do with that. Walk with me."

He stood up.

"I have a job for you, Mr. Wilson. A job that matters."

Matters.

The word hung in the air. The bait. The hook. The promise.

I stood up. I followed him.

Because I'm an idiot. And idiots always follow the shiny object.